User Experience Audit

DONORS CHOOSE

https://www.donorschoose.org

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CU Boulder

April, 2026

What to expect

The audit includes:
- A heuristic evaluation using Nielsen's 10 usability principles
- A WCAG accessibility rating covering screen reader, keyboard, and color contrast
- A persona study
- A site map and user flow diagram
- Page-specific findings for the Homepage, About us, Partner with us, and sub-navigation

About



Parker Allen

I am a designer with a background in web development, graphic design and social media marketing, currently studying Creative Technology and Design at the University of Colorado Boulder.

My coursework includes ATLS 4720: User Experience Design 2, an advanced UX strategy course focused on research methodologies, prototyping practices, and the design of branded product experiences across global contexts.

Overview

- Business Context
- Accessibility
- Persona
- Heuristics
- Visual Design / Content
- User Flow Map

Scope and objective

Scope

Key areas of focus:
Sub-navigation, visual design, information architecture and content, heuristic evaluation, and the flow from homepage to successfully placed donation.

Key pages reviewed:
Homepage, Find a Classroom, Partner with Us, About Us, and Help. These pages were selected for their high cognitive load, complex user flows, content density, and accessibility concerns.

Objective

DonorsChoose is a nonprofit platform connecting teachers in need of classroom resources with donors who want to support public education. This audit evaluates the site through the lens of its two primary users, teachers seeking donations and donors.

The objective is to identify opportunities to restructure the content, navigation, heuristics, and visual design so that teachers have the highest possible chance of receiving funding and donors experience the lowest possible cognitive load.

Business Context

Product overview

DonorsChoose is a platform that connects teachers to donors.

Business goals

- Maximize donations
- Lower the barrier for teachers to create and share project requests, grow and retain an active donor base, expand corporate and foundation partnerships
- Build trust through transparency in how donations are used.

Competitors

classwish

AdoptAClassroom.org

amazon

gofundme

User Demographic

Age range

Teachers: **25–45**
Donors: from **young adults** to **retirees**

Geographic Location

Traffic is mostly **national**, with growing traffic from Nigeria and India.

Technical proficiency

Primarily middle aged professionals,-profesionals, or retirees.

This leaves the technical ability at mostly **average, or above average**.

Social breakdown

29% of social traffic originates from Nextdoor.

Community-motivated donors arrive with high emotional investment.

Device type

According to *Similarweb* (Jan–Mar 2026), 56.30% of traffic arrives via **mobile** web.

Language and literacy level

The site is **English-only**

Literacy level varies significantly across the donor base

Visual Design

Typography

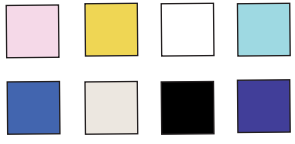
Fonts used:

Proxima Nova - Extrabold

Proxima Nova - Semibold

Proxima Nova - Medium

Color



Imagery and Iconography

Alignment

Layout and Hierarchy

White space

Content

Voice and consistency

- DonorsChoose maintains a consistently upbeat, yet professional tone across all pages.
- Terminology is uniform, “sign in” is consistently used across the site, and formatting conventions are consistent throughout.
- The brand voice feels natural.

Help and documentation

- Empty states are handled well. When no search results are found, suggestions are offered.
- Micro-content such as progress indicators and form validation messages are present and functional.
- Navigation instructions between pages could be clearer.

CTA effectiveness

- CTA buttons are unclear where they lead, and many route users to pages that repeat content from elsewhere on the site.
- Only the browser’s back arrow can lead the user back to where they were.
- Labels like “Learn more” and “Tell me more” are used interchangeably for similar actions.

Heuristics

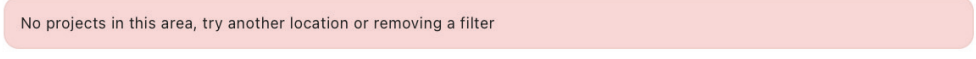
H3 — User control and freedom — Poor

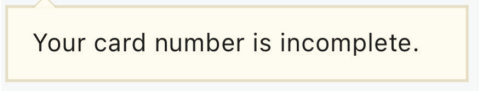
Users have limited ways to back out of actions or recover from navigation mistakes. There are no back buttons or arrows on internal pages, and only the browser back arrow is provided. Pop-ups have no close affordance, and users must infer that to leave the pop-up, they must click anywhere else on the screen.

The Help Center is the weakest in this area. Each topic opens to its own page with no nav or back arrow, so users must use the browser to return to the help index.

H5 — Error prevention — Neutral

There isnt much room for error on the site, as most of the pages are just informational content, but there were 2 minor areas with issues:
- The Find a Classroom map filter allows multiple selections without specifying which combination pairs are valid
- Buttons open new tabs with no warning or way back.
- The Help page hides the main nav as soon as a user enters “How can we help you,”





H6 — Recognition rather than recall — Poor

Information is buried and hard to locate. Pages are accessible through the main nav, or through sub-navigation on ceritan pages. The user has no context for how they arrived on a page, or which page they are on. The user is forced to remember the steps that they have taken to get to a page. CTA buttons lead the user to one-of-a-kind pages that are difficult to relocate.

H7 — Flexibility and efficiency of use — Neutral

The site is approachable for new users, but the wording of the content supports users that appear to already be motivated to make a donation.

Accessibility

Color contrast

Low contrast on hover states:

Before



After





Maggie Holloway

70 · Retired elementary school librarian · Rural community

Trust and confidence

Teacher testemonials, school names, and classroom-specfic product descriptions gove her the information that she needs.

Goals

- Donate directly to her grand-daughter's classroom.
- Confirm her payment reached that specific project.
- Share the project link with her daughter and friends from church.

Maggie has lived in the same small town for 42 years. She heard about DonorsChoose from a former volunteer of Emma's school.

Technical context

Above average for her age.
Reads page content rather than scanning.

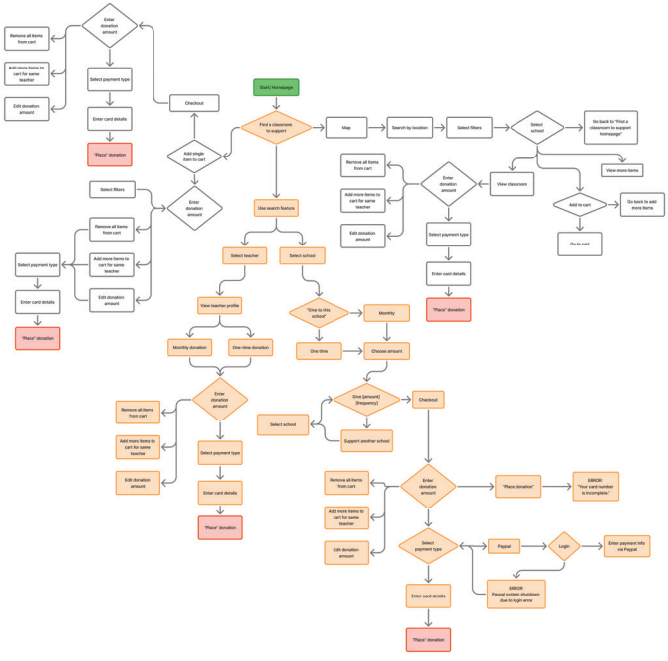
Constraints

Vision
Memory
Pace

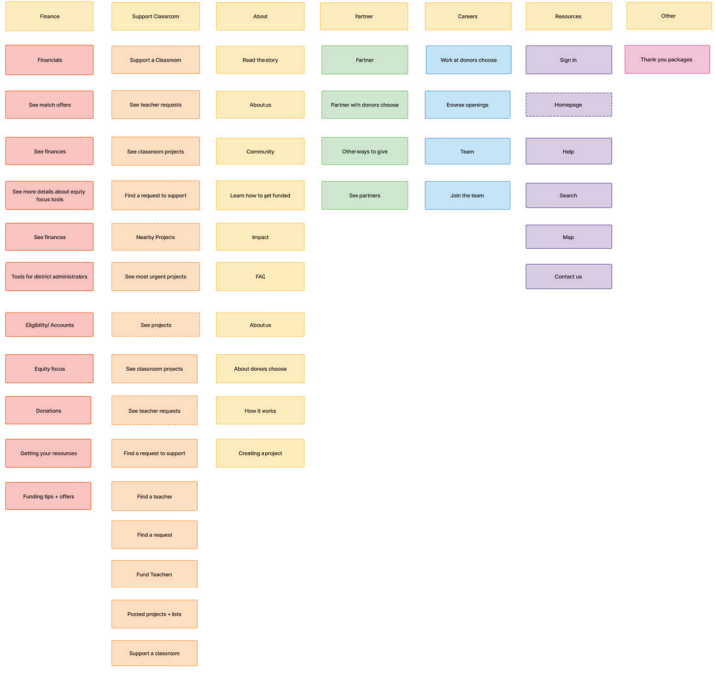
Key barriers

Maggie can make an educated guess to which page to choose, but must enter each page to find the type of information she is looking for. This is draining due to her declining memory.

User Flow Map



Information Architecture



Findability

Content hierarchy

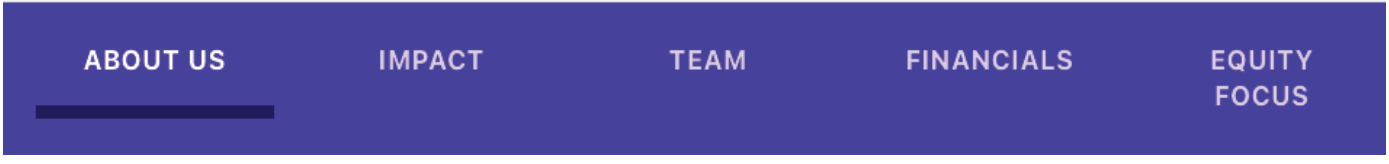
Labeling consistency

Wayfinding

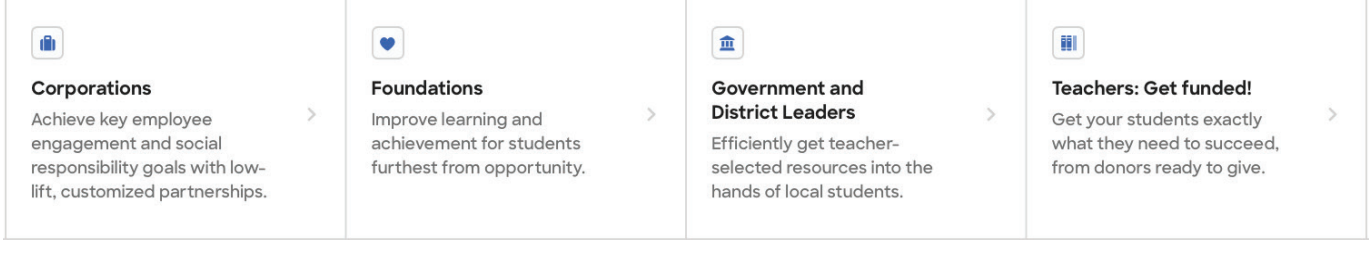
Navigation

Subnavigation

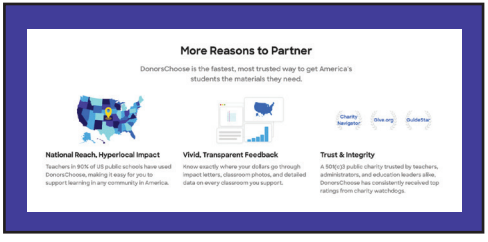
About Us

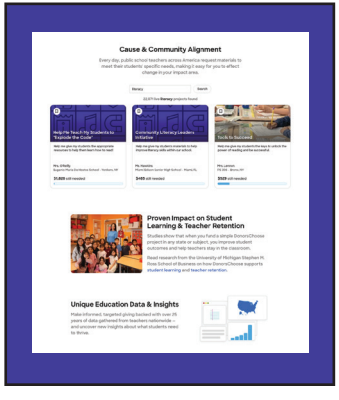


Partner with us




DonorsChoose connects funders to classrooms in need for a transformative giving experience.
National Reach, Hyperlocal Impact
Teachers in 90% of US public schools have used DonorsChoose, making it easy for you to support learning in any community in America.
Vivid, Transparent Feedback
Know exactly where your dollars go through impact letters, classroom photos, and detailed data on every classroom you support.
Charity Navigator
Give.org
GuideStar
Trust & Integrity
A 501(c)3 public charity trusted by teachers, administrators, and education leaders alike, DonorsChoose has consistently received top ratings from charity watchdogs.


More Reasons to Partner
DonorsChoose is the fastest, most trusted way to get America's students the materials they need.
National Reach, Hyperlocal Impact
Teachers in 90% of US public schools have used DonorsChoose, making it easy for you to support learning in any community in America.
Vivid, Transparent Feedback
Know exactly where your dollars go through impact letters, classroom photos, and detailed data on every classroom you support.
Charity Navigator
Give.org
GuideStar
Trust & Integrity
A 501(c)3 public charity trusted by teachers, administrators, and education leaders alike, DonorsChoose has consistently received top ratings from charity watchdogs.


Cause & Community Alignment
Every day, public school teachers across America request materials to meet their students' specific needs, making it easy for you to affect change in your impact area.
Proven Impact on Student Learning & Teacher Retention
Studies show that when you fund a simple DonorsChoose project in any state or subject, you improve student outcomes and help teachers stay in the classroom.
Read research from the University of Michigan Stephen M. Ross School of Business on how DonorsChoose supports student learning and teacher retention.
Unique Education Data & Insights


Cause & Community Alignment
Every day, public school teachers across America request materials to meet their students' specific needs, making it easy for you to affect change in your impact area.
Brand Lift Through Impact Storytelling
Teacher testimonials, classroom photos, and tangible impact metrics make it easy for you to show customers, employees, and local leaders how you're investing in their community.
Explore award-winning DonorsChoose partnerships >
Inspire Your Workforce
Engage employees in your giving by connecting them with classrooms in need. Whether you're piling on rewards to fund fix-exchanging letters with classrooms, leaders and frontline staff alike can make a meaningful impact for their communities.
Learn about our micro-volunteering letter-writing program, Classroom Connections >
Robotics Program Funding

Reccomendations

High priority

- Add dropdowns to the main navigation so users can preview section contents
- SImplify the four About sub-pages into a single drop down in the nav bar
- Merge the Foundations and Find a Classroom sub-page
- Eliminate redundant content on Partner with Us page
- Add back arrows on all internal pages so users aren't dependent on the browser back button
- Restore the main nav on the Help Center and all internal help topic pages
- Clarify Find a Classroom filter rules so users know which combinations work together.

Medium priority

- Move teacher testimonials and classroom stories higher on the homepage
- Standardize CTA labels — “Learn more” vs “Tell me more”
- Replace “highest economic need,” “most donors” with simpler alternatives
- Strengthen hover state contrast on buttons
- Add page headers so users know where they are on the site
- Add close affordances (×) on all pop-ups
- Add a small confirmation before buttons that open new tabs

Lower priority

- Resolve nested links so screen readers don’t repeat the same message twice
- Fix the z-position ordering issue (developers)
- Reduce vertical page length on long pages to improve mobile usability

Strengths

Variety of information

- Detailed teacher profiles
- FAQ sections throughout the site
- Empty states handled well, clear messaging when no results are found

Visual design

- Consistent white space and margins
- Strong color contrast on text
- Clear typographic hierarchy
- Cohesive color palette
- On-brand imagery of teachers and students
- Minimal icon style

Brand

- Warm, conversational tone
- Uniform terminology

Accessibility

- Most text and background combinations meet WCAG AA standards
- All interactive elements reachable via keyboard tab navigation
- Focus indicator remains visible throughout keyboard navigation
- Screen reader is clear and logically ordered with only minor issues

Audit scope

Pages in scope: Homepage, Find a Classroom, About us, Partner with us, Help Center

Methods used

- Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics with pass / neutral / fail ratings
- WCAG accessibility evaluation including screen reader, keyboard navigation, and color contrast
- Donor persona
- User flow
- Traffic analysis sourced from Similarweb

Areas evaluated

- User demographics
- Visual design: typography, color, alignment, layout, white space, imagery
- Content: voice, consistency, help and documentation
- Information architecture: navigation, findability, content hierarchy, labeling, wayfinding
- Page-specific findings — Homepage, About us, Partner with us, Sub navigation

Thank you!